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1. Unit Context

As an emerging teacher who has not yet begun student teaching, I have limited experience with full instructional planning in a classroom setting. This unit, however, draws deeply from my earlier fieldwork and storytelling experiences, which have informed my understanding of how young learners engage with literacy and cultural narratives. My student teaching placement is scheduled for later this year, and in the meantime, I have relied on observations, read-aloud sessions, and curriculum design coursework to thoughtfully prepare this unit.

Last year, I completed a field experience in a first-grade classroom at Francis Parker School #23, where I had the opportunity to observe and assist with early literacy instruction. In addition to that, I volunteered at a local library to lead storytime sessions for young children. During these sessions, I found that children responded with excitement and curiosity when I introduced elements of Chinese culture—such as dragon dances, red envelopes, and mooncakes. Their enthusiastic engagement inspired me to create a unit that would allow for deeper exploration of these topics in a classroom setting.

Because of these experiences, I chose to focus this unit on **three major traditional Chinese festivals: Chinese New Year (春节), the Lantern Festival (元宵节), and the Mid-Autumn Festival (中秋节).** These festivals were selected because they represent key themes in Chinese cultural life—family unity, seasonal transitions, mythological storytelling, and symbolic ritual. More importantly, they offer rich entry points for young learners to practice literacy skills through joyful, participatory learning.

This unit is designed for first-grade students in a face-to-face learning environment. The classroom is composed of learners from a range of cultural and linguistic backgrounds. The unit invites students to explore Chinese traditions through multimodal, culturally sustaining practices that center storytelling, art-making, and personal reflection. By acknowledging the social, historical, and linguistic experiences of students, the unit fosters inclusion, belonging, and curiosity.

This is an interdisciplinary unit that weaves together social studies and English Language Arts (ELA). Students explore Chinese cultural traditions through literacy-rich experiences that involve reading, speaking, writing, listening, and visual arts. Drawing on students' prior knowledge and lived experiences, the unit employs culturally sustaining pedagogies (Paris & Alim, 2017) to deepen understanding and promote equity. Through collaborative storytelling, reflective writing, and community-focused inquiry, students will come to see both their own and others' cultures as valuable and worthy of celebration.

2. Unit Description and Purpose

This three-week unit introduces first-grade students to three major traditional Chinese festivals: **Chinese New Year, the Lantern Festival, and the Mid-Autumn Festival**. Through culturally grounded storytelling, art-making, guided discussions, and literacy-rich activities, students will explore the historical significance, customs, and symbolic meanings of each celebration. Each lesson provides opportunities for students to engage in developmentally appropriate reading, writing, listening, and speaking tasks while also reflecting on family, tradition, and identity.

Although I have not yet begun my student teaching placement, this unit is grounded in insights gained from a prior field experience at Francis Parker School #23, as well as my volunteer work leading storytime sessions at a public library. In both settings, I witnessed the ways in which children enthusiastically responded to cultural content—particularly stories, images, and hands-on activities related to Chinese festivals. These experiences showed me how literacy learning can be both joyful and meaningful when students feel connected to the material.

By focusing on three Chinese festivals, the unit not only fosters appreciation for global traditions but also opens a space for critical inquiry into how culture, identity, and history are represented in schools. Students are encouraged to compare their own family practices with those portrayed in the stories and consider questions such as: “Whose stories do we read in school?” and “Why do we know more about some holidays than others?” These reflections help students recognize the ways in which cultural narratives are included—or excluded—in dominant educational spaces (Muhammad, 2020; McLaughlin & DeVogd, 2004). By discussing how traditions connect to identity and belonging, students begin to challenge the idea that there is one ‘normal’ way to celebrate, and instead appreciate the diversity of human experience. In this way, the unit supports students in developing the tools to question norms and become thoughtful, inclusive members of their communities.

Standards Alignment

Social Studies –

- 1.6c: People from diverse backgrounds and cultures celebrate different holidays and festivals.
- 1.1a: Students describe events in their lives, including cultural traditions and celebrations.

ELA – Next Generation Learning Standards:

- 1R1: Develop and answer questions about key ideas and details in a text.
- 1R3: Describe characters, settings, and major events in a story.

- 1SL1: Participate in collaborative conversations with peers and adults.
- 1W2: Write informative/explanatory texts with a topic, facts, and closure.
- 1SL4: Describe events and express ideas clearly with relevant details.

3. Literacies Framework (Muhammad's Five Pursuits)

- **Identity:**

This unit encourages students to explore their own cultural identities by reflecting on the traditions and celebrations they experience at home. As students learn about Chinese New Year, the Lantern Festival, and the Mid-Autumn Festival, they are invited to draw comparisons with holidays and practices that are meaningful in their own families.

Through storytelling, personal connections, and classroom sharing, students begin to recognize that culture lives not only in books, but in their everyday lives. For me as a developing teacher, incorporating this pursuit is also a reflection of my own journey of connecting cultural heritage to teaching practice.

- **Skills:**

Throughout the unit, students engage in foundational literacy practices aligned with first-grade standards. These include listening to and discussing read-aloud texts, sequencing events from cultural stories, participating in collaborative conversations, and writing descriptive or explanatory sentences. Multimodal formats—such as crafts, drawings, and oral retellings—support students in developing vocabulary, comprehension, and expressive language in accessible ways. The unit scaffolds both individual and social literacy growth through culturally meaningful content.

- **Intellect:**

Students deepen their knowledge of Chinese cultural traditions, symbols, and values through inquiry and discovery. They learn about the origins and meanings behind Chinese New Year, the Lantern Festival, and the Mid-Autumn Festival, and come to understand how each celebration marks time, honors family, and connects people across generations. Lessons integrate folktales, historical customs, and symbolic practices, offering students a rich context for cultural exploration. By drawing connections between stories and rituals, students begin to understand culture as both rooted in the past and alive in the present.

- **Criticality:**

Through comparison and conversation, students are guided to think about how different cultures are represented and valued in classroom spaces. By centering a non-Western cultural lens, this unit disrupts the dominant narrative that often limits cultural studies in early childhood classrooms to surface-level celebrations. Students ask questions such as: “Why do we only see some holidays in books or media?” and “What makes a tradition important?” What makes a night special for your family? Is your tradition in books or on

TV?” “Why do some stories get told in different ways? Can stories change depending on who tells them?” These reflections build early awareness of equity, inclusion, and representation, while cultivating a respectful appreciation for cultures different from their own.

- **Joy:**

Joy is interwoven throughout the unit in both content and pedagogy. From acting out the story of Nian to parading with handmade lanterns, students experience learning as playful, meaningful, and celebratory. The hands-on projects, music, storytelling, and community-building activities spark engagement and enthusiasm while reinforcing core literacy concepts. Joy is not treated as an add-on, but as a vital element of culturally sustaining teaching—where student interest, imagination, and emotion drive learning forward.

4. Lesson Plan

Teacher: Jina Cui		Grade Level: 1st Grade
Unite Name : Exploring Chinese Festivals Through Literacy and Storytelling		
Length of Unite: 3 weeks 9 lessons		
Week 1	Lesson 1 (5 min) Opening: Teacher welcomes students and introduces the topic. Ask: “Have you ever celebrated something with your family?” (10 min) Visual Inquiry: Show and discuss images of Chinese New Year. Ask: “What do you notice?” “What colors and shapes do you see?” (15 min) Read-Aloud: Read <i>D is for Dragon Dance</i> . Pause to explain key vocabulary: dumplings, red envelopes, lanterns. (20 min) Art Activity: Students create their own dragon masks using art supplies. (10 min) Sharing Circle: Each student shares their dragon mask and says one thing they learned	Homework : Students will watch the celebration video and complete their masks and share one new vocabulary word or tradition they learned during the lesson. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zm6091k_deM&t=37s

	about Chinese New Year.	
	Lesson 2 (5 min) Warm-Up Discussion: “Do you know any stories about monsters or heroes?” (10 min) Storytelling: Teacher tells the story of Nian using props or masks. Emphasize why people use red and loud sounds. (15 min) Role-Play: Students act out scenes from the story in small groups. Teacher helps guide scenes. (15 min) Art Activity: Students make their own firecracker craft to “scare away” Nian. (10 min) Whole-Class Reflection: Ask: “What part of the story did you like best?” “Why do we use stories to explain traditions?”	Homework : Students demonstrate understanding by retelling parts of the Nian story and explaining the symbolism behind their firecracker crafts. The legend of Nian https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Np4QzM8QEZg
	Lesson 3 (5 min) Review Discussion: Ask students to recall what they’ve learned so far. (15 min) Video Viewing: Watch a short video about family traditions during Chinese New Year. Pause to ask: “What are they doing?” “Why?” (10 min) Class Discussion: Compare Chinese traditions with students’ own family traditions. Make a chart of similarities and differences. Have you ever seen red envelopes in a store or a book? Why don’t we see all holidays shown the same way? Who decides which traditions are common? (20 min) Art Activity: Students decorate red envelopes and write/draw one wish or blessing inside. (10 min) Sharing Circle: Each	Homework : Students demonstrate understanding through written or oral descriptions of red envelope symbolism and how it connects to family.

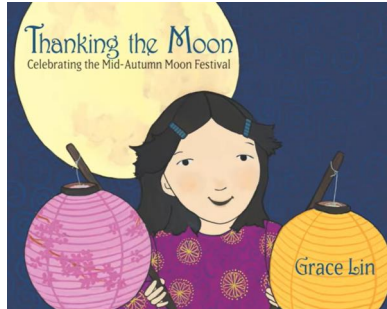
	student presents their envelope and explains who they would give it to.	
Week 2	Lesson 4 (5 min) Opening Connection: Show pictures of nighttime lantern celebrations. Ask: “Where have you seen lights used in a celebration?” “What feelings do they give you?” (10 min) Read-Aloud: Read <i>Magic Chinese Lantern</i>. Focus on how the lantern helps guide and protect the character. Ask, “What does the lantern do in this story?”  (10 min) Class Discussion: Introduce the Lantern Festival as the final day of Chinese New Year. Explain that lanterns represent hope, reunion, and joy. Ask: “What might you wish for in the new year?” (20 min) Lantern Craft with Wishes: • Model step-by-step folding and cutting of lanterns. • Students decorate lanterns with personal colors and designs. • On a card or sticker, students write a wish or blessing (e.g., “I wish my mom is healthy,” “I want to be a good friend”). • They attach the wish tag to	Homework : Draw a Lantern Festival Night Scene Instructions: Draw a picture of a Lantern Festival night. Use lots of colors to show the lights and lanterns. Then write one sentence to describe your picture. Sentence starters (choose one): • At night, I see many lanterns. • My favorite lantern is shaped like a _____. • The lights make me feel _____.

	their lantern. (10 min) Partner Share: Students present their lanterns and read their wishes to a partner or small group.	
	Lesson 5 (5 min) Introduction: Explain the riddle tradition of the Lantern Festival. Ask: “Have you ever tried solving a riddle? What makes them fun?” (10 min) Whole-Class Riddle Practice: Read aloud 3–4 riddles with gestures or images. Let students guess as a group. Do all families play games or tell riddles during holidays? Why do some cultures’ games become well-known while others don’t? (15 min) Create Your Own Riddle: • Students pick an object (e.g., the moon, a cat, a dumpling). • They draw a visual clue and write (or dictate) a simple riddle. • Teacher/assistant helps with wording. (10 min) Riddle Gallery Walk: • Display all riddles on the “Lantern Riddle Wall.” • Students walk with a buddy and guess each riddle.	Homework : Students will create an original riddle and explain its meaning during the gallery walk.

	(10 min) Riddle Theater (New!): • In small groups, students act out one of their riddles using movements only. • Class guesses: “Is it the moon?” “Is it a rabbit?” • Applaud creative thinking and teamwork.	
	Lesson 6 (5 min) Parade Prep: Students review how to hold lanterns. Practice moving gently in a line. Discuss parade behavior: “Walk slowly, shine bright.” (15 min) Lantern Parade: • Turn down lights and play background music. • Students walk with lanterns around the classroom or hallway. • Teachers/peers clap quietly, admire each other’s work. • Optional: Take photos and display on a class bulletin board. (10 min) Whole-Class Reflection Talk: • Gather on the carpet. Ask: ○ “How did it feel to walk with your lantern?”	Homework : Draw yourself holding your lantern during the parade. Add any details you remember—music, friends, decorations, or how the room looked.

	○ “What did the light remind you of?” ○ “Why do people walk together in a celebration?” (15 min) “Family and Light” Drawing & Writing: ● Prompt: “Have you ever made something or shared a special night with your family?” ● Students draw that moment and write a sentence using a stem like: ○ “I made ____ with ____.” ○ “We celebrated ____ together.” ○ “It made me feel ____.” (5 min) Optional Share-Out: Invite volunteers to present their drawings and sentences.	
Week 3	Lesson 7 (5 min) Warm-Up Discussion: Show students pictures of mooncakes and families sitting outdoors under the moon. Ask: “What do you think people are doing?” “Have you ever had a special night with your family?” (15 min) Read-Aloud & Think-Aloud: Read <i>Thanking the Moon</i>. Pause at key pages to ask: “What are they celebrating?” “Why is the moon important to them?” “What do you do at night with your	Homework : Students will watch a video, complete and present a mooncake design and explain the meaning of at least one element. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_PyF4LCcnnrQ

family?"<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=35ffJbbR7E>



(10 min) Class Talk: Introduce the Mid-Autumn Festival as a time for family reunion and moon appreciation. Show different styles of mooncakes. Explain the symbolic meaning of their round shape (unity, completeness).

(20 min) Mooncake Design Activity:

- Students receive paper mooncake outlines.
- They decorate their mooncake with patterns and symbols (e.g., hearts for love, stars for night, fruits for sharing).
- Inside the mooncake, students write or dictate one wish or something they would share with their family.

(10 min) Sharing Circle: Students hold up their mooncakes and share their meaning: "I put ____ because ____."

Lesson 8

(5 min) Background Talk: Ask, "Have you ever heard a story about the moon?" Introduce that in Chinese culture, people tell a story about a woman who lives on the moon.

Homework :

Students retell or describe a part of the story through their drawing and sentence.
Informal assessment during

	-Why do some stories get told in different ways? Can stories change depending on who tells them? (15 min) Oral Storytelling: • Teacher tells the story of Chang'e, Hou Yi, the magic potion, and the moon rabbit. • Use visuals or hand gestures to represent each part. • Emphasize key events: the gift, the choice, and Chang'e floating to the moon. • Ask comprehension questions: "Why didn't Hou Yi chase her?" "Why do people look at the moon and remember her?" (15 min) Drawing Activity: • Students draw their favorite scene from the story. • Underneath, they write (or dictate) a sentence: "My favorite part was ____ because ____." (10 min) Partner Share & Mini-Retell: • Students take turns showing their drawing to a partner. • With help, they describe what's happening in the picture and what it tells about the story.	pair-sharing and oral recall.
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	(5 min) Whole-Class Wrap-Up: Create a class timeline of the story with 3–4 main events.	
	Lesson 9 (5 min) Class Discussion: Ask, “What does your family do when the sun goes down?” “Have you ever looked at the moon together?” (10 min) Image Inspiration: Project or show photos of families sitting outside under the full moon. Talk about what people do when they gather: eat, talk, sing, remember loved ones. (10 min) Guided Drawing Prompt: • “Think of a night that felt special with your family.” • “What did you do? Who was there? How did it feel?” • Students begin to sketch a scene from that memory. (15 min) Drawing and Writing: • Students complete their illustration. • Use sentence stems to help them write (or dictate) 1–2 sentences about the moment. • Teacher provides spelling or scribing support as needed. (10 min) Sharing Circle: Invite each student to share their memory aloud. Others can respond: “That	Homework : Students express a personal memory through drawing and writing. Assessment based on participation and expression rather than mechanics.

	reminds me of..." or "I felt that way too." -What makes a night special for your family? Is your tradition in books or on TV?	

5. Create a example

Sample Presentation:

<https://www.canva.com/design/DAGkvolbW4Y/inTTvMucWgQDN7sy6slrJg/edit>

Sample Assignments:

<https://docs.google.com/document/d/1GR6zOvPEL3ojCSA1H-f1EbR3fy8wVxGrS7nSDIk5GsM/edit?tab=t.0>

6. Unit Reflection

Challenge Overcome:

One of the main challenges I faced while creating this unit was designing detailed and developmentally appropriate lesson plans without having prior experience in student teaching. Because I have not yet begun my official placement, I lacked firsthand knowledge of classroom management strategies, pacing, and how students might respond to specific activities. To overcome this, I drew heavily on my fieldwork experience in a first-grade classroom at Francis Parker School #23, where I observed how students interacted with stories, crafts, and cultural topics. I also relied on my volunteer work at the local library, where I engaged children through storytelling. These experiences helped me imagine what types of lessons would be both age-appropriate and culturally responsive. Additionally, I sought out research-based frameworks such as Muhammad's Five Pursuits and Universal Design for Learning (CAST, 2018) to guide the structure and goals of each lesson, ensuring that all learners could access and enjoy the content.

Takeaway:

Through this unit planning process, I learned that thoughtful curriculum design requires more than just aligning standards—it also involves honoring students' identities, interests, and ways of knowing. I realized the importance of creating joyful and inclusive learning environments where students not only build literacy skills but also see their own cultures and stories reflected in the classroom. As an emerging educator, I will carry this understanding into future lesson planning by incorporating culturally sustaining texts, hands-on storytelling, and opportunities for student reflection and voice. Most importantly, I learned that even in the absence of direct classroom experience, I can still draw from observation, research, and my own cultural background to create meaningful and engaging learning experiences.

